

Memory Problems

Memory problems increase with age, and dementia affects one in six people over 80. Sometimes, brain damage, stress, or other factors can cause us to experience an inability to remember (amnesia).

Amnesia

If someone suffers a brain injury that damages the hippocampus and surrounding areas, it can cause amnesia. There are two main types, depending on whether the patient forgets memories they had stored before the incident (retrograde amnesia) or is unable to form new memories (anterograde amnesia). There are also cases of amnesia without any obvious signs of damage, for example, after experiencing a psychological trauma. Drugs and alcohol can cause temporary amnesia, although this can become permanent if large amounts are used over a long period. It is also possible to suffer anterograde and retrograde amnesia at once, particularly if there is significant damage to the hippocampus. This condition is called global amnesia.



Retrograde amnesia

People often forget moments before an accident, but they can lose weeks, or even years. Some memories, especially older ones, return slowly.



Anterograde amnesia

People with anterograde amnesia are unable to form new memories. They remember who they are and retain memories from before the damage.



Transient global amnesia

This is a sudden episode of memory loss, typically lasting a few hours. There are no other symptoms or obvious cause.



Infantile amnesia

Infantile amnesia refers to the fact that people usually cannot retrieve memories of situations or events before the age of two to four years.

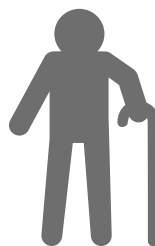


Dissociative amnesia

This can be triggered by stress or psychological trauma. Patients forget days or weeks around the trauma or, in rare "fugue states," who they are.

Aging and memory

As we age, it is normal to experience memory lapses and encounter more difficulty learning new things. Focusing attention and ignoring distractions becomes harder, and you may forget everyday things, such as why you went upstairs, more often. These experiences differ from the symptoms of dementia (see p.200), which can include getting lost in your own house or forgetting a partner's name.

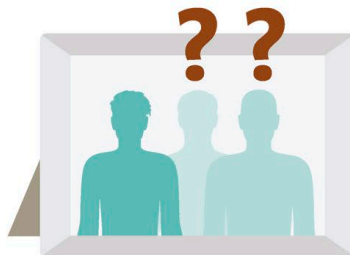


BY THE TIME PEOPLE REACH THEIR 80s, THEY MAY HAVE LOST AS MUCH AS 20 PERCENT OF THE NERVE CONNECTIONS IN THEIR HIPPOCAMPUS



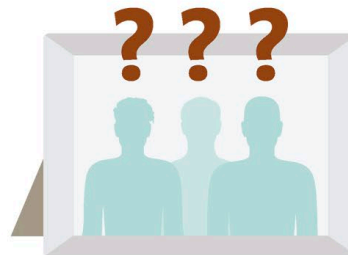
1 Losing trust in memory

Older adults often begin doubting their memories, seeing normal lapses as a sign of worsening abilities. This can lead them to rely on it less.



2 Using memory less

Brain abilities are like muscles, getting stronger with use. Writing things down or looking them up instead of exercising your memory could make it worse.



3 Memory getting worse

Not exercising your memory can cause a vicious cycle of cognitive decline. Encouraging older adults to use their memory, by providing feedback showing it still functions well, may help.